ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Engineering English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For mechanical, electrical, civil, systems, industrial, test, quality, manufacturing, and field engineers, plus engineering managers and technical project leads.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

acceptance criteria
Specific conditions a deliverable must meet to be accepted.

code compliance
Conformity with the applicable building, engineering, or other technical code requirements.

configuration management
Controlling and recording the versions and settings of a system or product.

constraint
A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible.

corrective action
Action taken to fix a current problem and prevent recurrence.

cycle time
The time needed to complete one defined production or work cycle.

design rationale
The reasons and evidence supporting a design choice.

design review
A structured evaluation of a design at a defined stage.

DFM
Design for manufacturability: shaping a design so it can be made effectively and consistently.

duty cycle
The pattern of operating time and conditions used to describe equipment use.

failure mode
A specific way in which a component, process, or system can fail.

field failure
A product failure occurring during use outside the development or production setting.

FMEA
Failure mode and effects analysis, a structured method for identifying how a process or product can fail and prioritizing controls.

installation condition
A circumstance of how or where equipment was installed that may affect its performance.

integration
Connecting components or organizations so they work together as intended.

interface control
Managing the agreed technical relationships between components or systems.

liability
Legal responsibility or an obligation; in accounting, an amount or duty owed.

margin
The difference or allowance between values; in business, a measure of profitability.

prototype
An early version used to explore or test a design.

regression test
A test checking whether a change has broken previously working behavior.

reliability
The ability to perform an intended function consistently under stated conditions over time.

requirement
A condition or capability that must be met for a stated purpose.

risk
Uncertainty that may affect objectives or expose people or assets to harm or loss.

safety factor
A defined design ratio or allowance addressing uncertainty between expected loading and capacity.

sample size
The number of independent units or observations included in a defined analysis.

tolerance
The permitted variation from a specified value or dimension.

tooling
Equipment or fixtures used to shape, assemble, or produce a product.

tradeoff
A choice that improves one objective while giving up something on another.

validation
Confirming that an output or system meets needs for its intended use under defined conditions.

verification
Checking whether specified requirements have been met.

warranty
A promise or contractual assurance about a product or work, with defined terms and remedies.

yield
The proportion of production meeting defined requirements; in finance, a return measure with a different calculation.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Disagree with a useful reason

I understand the goal. My concern is ... .

That statement goes beyond ... .

Could we ... before confirming ...?

Acknowledge the goal without pretending agreement. Name the specific problem and its implication, then ask a focused question or propose a next step. Be direct when a safety or ethical boundary requires it.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but ... .

Option A ..., whereas option B ... .

The comparison depends on ... .

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for ... . The correct information is ... .

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses ... .

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is ... .

The record shows ... .

Please confirm who has accepted ... .

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Requirements and Constraints

A customer asks for a "lightweight and durable" enclosure without specifying weight, operating conditions, or required life.

Could you define the target weight, operating conditions, and expected life? We need measurable requirements to discuss the tradeoffs and evaluate a design consistently.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Design Reviews and Technical Pushback

A design review is moving toward approval while one interface assumption remains undocumented.

I support moving the review forward, but this interface assumption needs to be explicit. Could we record it and identify the verification needed before treating that part of the design as settled?

Try it again: The other person repeats the request more firmly. Restate the specific concern calmly and explain the appropriate next route.

03 | Failure Modes and Reliability

A component fails during one test. The team has not reproduced the failure or checked the test setup.

The failure occurred in this test, but its mechanism is not established. I'll describe the observed behavior and test conditions separately from the possible explanations.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

04 | Testing, Validation, and Data Interpretation

A prototype passes a test on three samples. A presentation calls the design proven for every operating condition.

The three samples met the criteria under the tested conditions. That does not establish performance under every condition. I'll state the sample size and limits of the test clearly.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

05 | Manufacturability and Cost Engineering

Two designs use different tooling and assembly steps. One has a lower material cost but higher assembly time.

The material cost favors the first design, while assembly time favors the second. Let's compare the full manufacturing assumptions before calling either design cheaper overall.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

06 | Safety Factors and Compliance

A review note says a design is "compliant" without identifying the applicable requirement or review evidence.

Could you identify the requirement, revision, and supporting evidence for that statement? We need a traceable basis for the compliance claim and review by the responsible specialist.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

07 | Field Issues and Customer Communication

A customer received a field-failure update that stated an unconfirmed cause as fact. The investigation is still open.

Our earlier update overstated the cause. The investigation is still open, and the confirmed finding is the observed failure described below. I'm sorry for the confusion; we'll clearly label hypotheses in future updates.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

08 | Systems Integration and Interface Control

A hardware interface changed after software testing began. The integration team needs the version and affected tests.

The interface changed in this revision. I've listed the affected signals and tests for review. Please confirm the configuration your team will use and which checks need to be repeated.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.